

# Transition Planning Toolkit

## Age 14 to Adult Life — A Complete Guide for Families

*Knowledge is power. Partnership is progress. Together — the IEP gets APPROVED.*

### What Is Transition Planning?

Transition planning is the process of preparing your child for life after high school — whether that means college, vocational training, employment, independent living, or a combination. Under IDEA, transition services must be included in the IEP beginning no later than the first IEP in effect when a student turns 16. Many states require planning to begin at age 14.

**Transition planning is not about limiting your child's future — it is about building the bridge to get there.**

### The Legal Requirements

| Requirement            | Details                                                                                             |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Age of Planning        | No later than the first IEP in effect when the student turns 16 (many states require age 14)        |
| What Must Be Included  | Appropriate measurable postsecondary goals based on age-appropriate transition assessments          |
| Transition Services    | Coordinated set of activities designed to facilitate movement from school to post-school activities |
| Student Involvement    | The student must be invited to their IEP meeting when transition is discussed                       |
| Agency Involvement     | Representatives of outside agencies (vocational rehabilitation, etc.) may be invited                |
| Summary of Performance | When a student exits school, the district must provide a Summary of Performance document            |

### Age-by-Age Transition Planning Guide

#### Age 14 (or earlier)

- Begin discussing your child's interests, strengths, and dreams
- Request transition assessments (interest inventories, career assessments)
- Ensure transition goals are included in the IEP
- Explore extracurricular activities that build skills
- Connect with your state's vocational rehabilitation office

- Research post-secondary options: 4-year college, community college, vocational programs, supported employment

### Ages 15-16

- Review and refine postsecondary goals annually
- Explore work-based learning opportunities
- Begin teaching self-advocacy skills — your child should know their diagnosis and their rights
- Apply for Supplemental Security Income (SSI) at age 16 if appropriate
- Research college disability services if college is a goal
- Explore driver's education or transportation alternatives

### Ages 17-18

- Request Summary of Performance document from school
- Obtain copies of all evaluations and records
- Apply for adult services through your state DD agency
- Establish guardianship or supported decision-making if appropriate
- Apply to post-secondary programs
- Connect with vocational rehabilitation for employment support
- Register to vote

### Final Year of Eligibility

- Confirm all transition services are being provided
- Ensure Summary of Performance is completed
- Connect with all adult service agencies before exit
- Develop an emergency contact and support plan
- Celebrate what your child has achieved

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## Post-Secondary Options to Explore

**4-Year College:** Students with disabilities who meet academic requirements can attend college with disability services support. The ADA and Section 504 require colleges to provide reasonable accommodations.

**Community College:** More flexible entry requirements, often with strong disability services. Can lead to certificates, associate degrees, or transfer to 4-year programs.

**Vocational/Technical Programs:** Career-focused training in specific trades and fields. Many offer supported programs for students with disabilities.

**Supported Employment:** Competitive integrated employment with job coaching and support. Vocational rehabilitation can fund these services.

**Day Programs:** Community-based programs focusing on skill development, socialization, and employment for adults who need more support.

**Independent Living:** Supported or fully independent living arrangements. Many states have housing programs and independent living centers.